

# AI 101 cheat sheet

How to talk to AI, and what all the words mean. Keep this next to your keyboard.

WORKS IN

ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini  
Copilot · any chatbot

## The 5-part prompt Use all five and your answers get better right away.

### R Role

Who should the AI act like? "You are a..."

### T Task

The one job you want done. Start with a verb.

### C Context

The background. Who it's for, what matters, what to avoid.

### F Format

How it should look. Length, tone, list or paragraph.

### E Example

Show one you like. AI copies examples really well.

#### BEFORE

"Write a post about my bakery."

You get something bland that sounds like everybody else.

#### AFTER

**You are a social media writer for a small family bakery. ROLE Write an Instagram caption for our new sweet potato pie. TASK It's my grandmother's recipe, sold on Fridays only. Our customers are busy parents. CONTEXT Keep it under 60 words, warm, end with a question. FORMAT Here's a caption we loved last month: "..."** **EXAMPLE**

## 3 rules that fix most answers

- 1 Talk to it like a smart new hire.**  
It's sharp, but it doesn't know you yet. Tell it what a new person would need to know.
- 2 It's a conversation, not a search.**  
Don't start over. Reply: "Shorter." "Sound more like me." "Give me 3 options."
- 3 Check anything that matters.**  
Names, numbers, dates, laws and links. AI can sound sure and still be wrong.

### HOW A CHAT WORKS

CONTEXT WINDOW = what it can see right now



Reply to make it better. Repeat.

## 12 AI words, in plain English

### AI

Computer programs that do things that used to take a person: write, answer, sum up.

### Prompt

What you type to the AI. Your instructions and your question.

### Training data

Everything the model learned from. It's why AI can be out of date.

### Hallucination

When AI makes something up and says it like a fact. So check.

### Generative AI

AI that makes something new: words, pictures, video, music.

### Model

The "brain" behind the chatbot. Some models are faster, some are smarter.

### Token

A small piece of a word. AI reads and counts in tokens.

### Custom instructions

Your background and rules, saved once, so you don't retype them. "Projects" work this way too.

### Chatbot

An AI you talk to by typing. ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini are chatbots.

### LLM

Large Language Model. The kind behind chatbots. It learned from a huge amount of writing.

### Context window

How much the AI can keep in mind at once. Long chats forget the start.

### Agent

An AI set up to do a whole job for you, step by step, and come back when it's done.